Little Fox Readers

Level 5

JOURNEY to the WEST 27

The Ginseng Fruit



Little Fox



The Tang Monk trembled with fear. The animals showed their fangs.

"Master!" cried Wukong.

The monkey was running fast. He swung his iron bar, and the animals ran back into the forest.

Wukong smiled. "Sorry for making the horse run, Master. I thought it would be funny."



The Tang Monk frowned. “It wasn’t funny at all! Those beasts were going to attack me!”

“Nonsense,” said Wukong. “You never have to fear any wild animals. You have three powerful companions.”

Bajie and Wujing soon caught up to them. They all continued along the road.

The Tang Monk pointed to a building up



ahead. “That looks like a Daoist abbey.”

“I’m sure the abbey’s priests will let us rest for a while,” said Wujing.

When they reached the abbey, Bajie knocked on the door. Two priests opened it.

“I’m here with the Tang Monk,” said the pig. “May we come in?”

The priests looked at the Tang Monk.

“Our master told us about you,” said one



of them. “He said you would travel past our abbey someday. Please, come in.”

“Who is your master?” asked the Tang Monk. “How did he know about me?”

“Our master is the Great Immortal,” said the first priest. “He is very wise and powerful.”

Wukong laughed. “I’ve never heard of him. I doubt he’s very powerful.”



The Tang Monk scowled. “Show some respect, Wukong,” he whispered.

The priests looked annoyed. “Our master is visiting friends in Heaven right now. If he wasn’t powerful, he wouldn’t be able to do that.”

Wukong shrugged. “I used to live in Heaven. The place isn’t that great.”

“Wukong,” said the Tang Monk. “Please



go outside and tend the horse."

Wukong went back outside. Wujing went out to get the bags.

"May I use the kitchen?" asked Bajie. "I want to cook some food for the Tang Monk."

"It's through that door," said one priest. He pointed to a door in the back of the room.

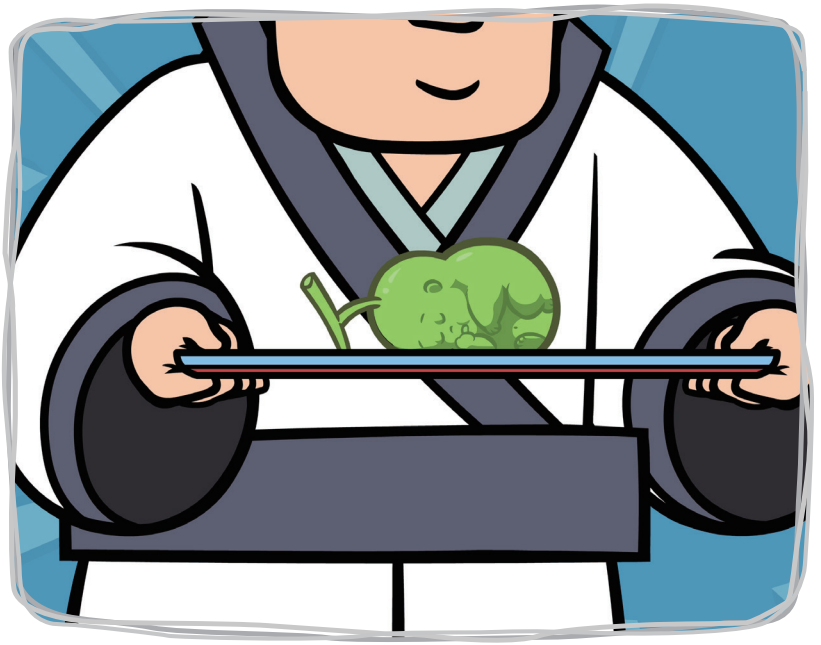
Bajie went into the kitchen while the Tang Monk talked to the priests.



"There's a ginseng tree behind the abbey," said one priest. "Its fruit takes ten thousand years to become ripe. According to legend, one bite of the fruit will make you live forever. Would you like one?"

"A fruit like that is a true treasure," said the Tang Monk. "Will your master be upset if I eat it?"

"Our master said we could give you one,"



said the other priest. “We’ll go and cut one down.”

The two priests went outside. A moment later they came back in with a tray. The Tang Monk screamed. On the tray lay a tiny sleeping baby.

“I can’t eat that,” cried the monk. “It—it’s a baby!”

“It’s not a baby,” said one priest. “It’s a

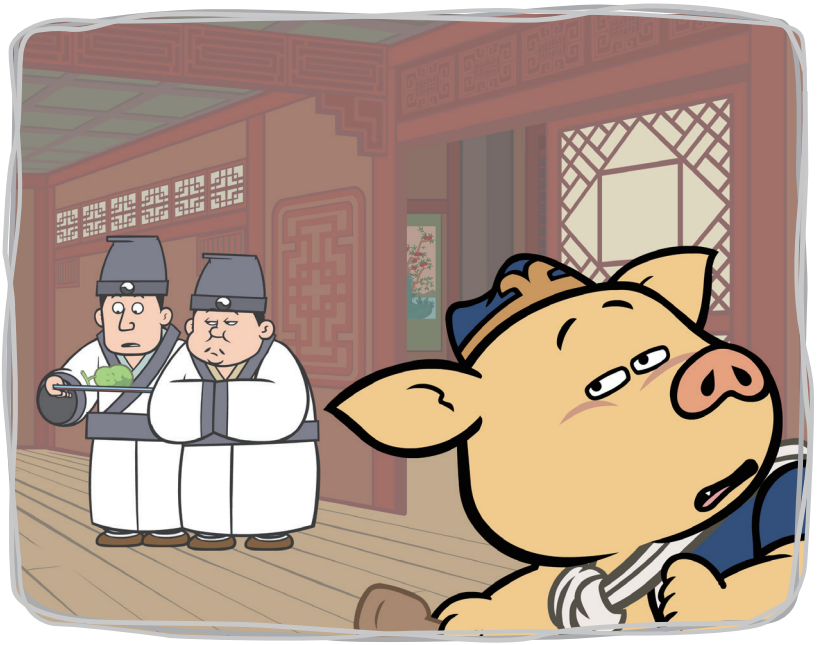


ginseng fruit. It only looks like a baby to you because you're a mortal."

"Please take it away!" cried the Tang Monk.

The priests tried to convince him that the fruit wasn't a baby. But the monk just shook his head. The priests took the ginseng fruit out of the room and into a hallway.

"We shouldn't waste this fruit," said one



priest.

"No," said the other. "It is too delicious and valuable. Let's eat it ourselves."

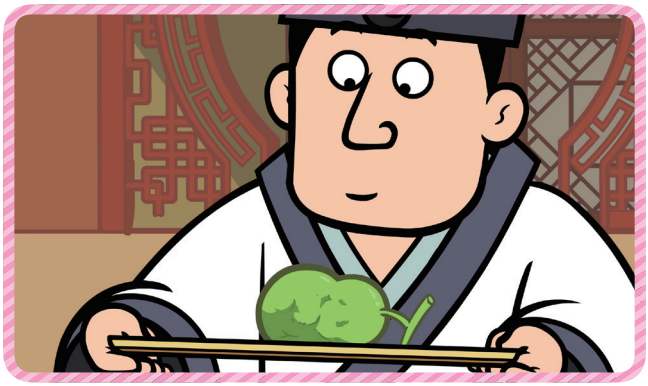
The two priests shared the ginseng fruit. Bajie was in the kitchen nearby. He had heard everything they'd said. His stomach growled.

"That fruit sounds wonderful," said Bajie to himself. "I want some too!"

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